have needed some time to reorganize following Rohullah's arrest, and the local Hizb-e-Islami commander along with foreign fighters associated with al-Qaeda were the ones believed to be leading the revolt at the time.[134] In 2003 insurgents from the Baujur Agency in Pakistan, where JuDQS and a host of other militant actors had a presence, increased raiding on positions close to the border. They linked up with Afghan fighters in the Korengal Valley, which in later years became the site of some of the bloodiest battles that US forces faced in Afghanistan. This brought a greater American presence and in November 2003 the US launched Operation Mountain Resolve, which contributed to making this a more active front. Lashkar had been working with JuDQS to transit weapons and other materials across the border to the Afghan Salafis in Kunar prior to 9/11, and stepped up its efforts afterwards to support them logistically.[135]

The consensus among the author's interlocutors is that it was not until roughly 2004–2005 that Lashkar entered the Afghan theater, a move that is explored in the following chapter. However, some of its members either took leave or split from the group to enter the Afghan front during the early years of the decade. For example, after 9/11 a commander known as Abu Shoaib argued for prioritizing the Afghan front over the jihad in Kashmir and when Lashkar's leaders demurred he formed a small outfit to fight there.[136] According to the interrogation by the Indian security services of a captured Indian operative named Abdul Razzak Masood, a Lashkar financier and facilitator called Arif Qasmani along with several other members of the group floated a militant outfit in 2003 for the purpose of supporting the insurgency in Afghanistan. One of those members was also known as Abu Shoaib.[137] It is not uncommon for different commanders to use the same kunya [nom de guerre] and so it is unclear whether this was the same commander or the same outfit. In either case, the US government alleges that Qasmani acted as a liaison for Lashkar with other militant outfits, was close to members of the Taliban and proffered financial as well as other support to al-Qaeda, including the provision of supplies and weapons as well.[138] Masood's testimony supports these assertions; in it he recounts Qasmani detailing his connections with the Taliban and al-Qaeda. He asserted that members of the new group, which Qasmani and others from Lashkar formed, fought alongside Arabs and other foreigners as well as Pakistanis against Coalition forces near Kunar province in 2003. Masood